

EMPLOYER SUPPORT LETTER — HARROWGATE COVENANT ASSEMBLY, INC.

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HARROWGATE COVENANT ASSEMBLY, INC.
A congregation of the Fourth Covenant Fellowship of North America
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Telephone (330) 555-0164 | office@harrowgatecovenant.example
EIN 41-3098776

January 22, 2026

U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services
Northwoods Service Center
Ferrisberg, MN 55164-0190

RE: Form I-129 petition for R-1 nonimmigrant religious worker classification
Beneficiary: Mr. Tobenna Chukwudi Ezeobi (DOB May 14, 1993, Nigeria)
Proffered position: Minister of Liturgical Music and Catechesis (religious occupation)

Dear Officer:

I write as Senior Pastor of Harrowgate Covenant Assembly, Inc. ("the Assembly") in support of the above petition. I have personal knowledge of the facts stated below.

1. THE PETITIONING ORGANIZATION

The Assembly was incorporated as an Ohio non-profit corporation on March 3, 1978, and has functioned continuously since that date as a congregation of the Fourth Covenant Fellowship of North America ("the Fellowship"), a denominational body headquartered at 22 Larkmoor Plaza, Duraine, IL 60188. The Assembly is tax exempt under section 501(c)(3) of the Internal Revenue Code through the Fellowship's group exemption. Our congregation currently has 612 enrolled communicant members and 47 catechumens.

We conduct two Sunday worship services (9:30 a.m. and 12:30 p.m.), a Wednesday evening choral vespers, and a Saturday liturgy of remembrance. Average combined Sunday attendance over the last twelve months was 384 persons.

2. THE FELLOWSHIP'S TEACHING ON SUNG LITURGY

The Fellowship's creed holds that the Covenant is transmitted in three forms: the read word, the sung word, and the taught word. For this reason our order of worship is fully sung, and the preparation of the sung word is treated in our tradition as a ministry of the Covenant rather than as a musical performance. The person who prepares and leads the sung word also carries responsibility for catechesis, because in our teaching the sung and taught word cannot be separated.

3. THE PROFFERED POSITION

The Assembly offers Mr. Ezeobi the position of Minister of Liturgical Music and Catechesis, a full-time position of 35 hours per week. Although the title contains the word "minister," the Assembly is petitioning for a religious occupation and not for classification as a minister; Mr. Ezeobi is a commissioned Covenant Cantor, not an ordained presbyter, and he will not administer the sacraments.

His duties will be:

1. Selecting the liturgical settings, psalm tones, and Covenant canticles for each service in accordance with the Fellowship's lectionary and the seasons of the Covenant year;
2. Leading the sung word at both Sunday services, at Wednesday choral vespers, and at the Saturday liturgy of remembrance;
3. Preparing and directing the adult choir and the junior choir in the doctrinal content of the texts they sing, not only in their music;
4. Instructing the youth catechesis class and the confirmation preparation class using the Fellowship's *Covenant Catechism, Fourth Edition*;
5. Preparing catechesis curriculum materials for the congregation's household study groups;
6. Providing pastoral music visitation to homebound members, including sung communion devotions;
7. Providing music and catechetical support for weddings, funerals, and other occasional liturgies;
8. Maintaining the Assembly's music library, instruments, and worship-space preparation, and assisting the church office with the administrative work that supports these programs.

Mr. Ezeobi will report directly to me as Senior Pastor and, on matters of liturgical order, to the Assembly's Worship Council.

4. COMPENSATION

The Board of Trustees has approved an annual salary of \$38,000, paid semi-monthly through the Assembly's payroll, together with a housing allowance of \$600 per month, employer-paid health coverage, and four weeks of paid leave. This position has been a salaried staff position of the Assembly since 2011 and was most recently held by Ms. Rowena Talbert-Ige, who resigned in September 2025 to relocate with her family.

5. THE BENEFICIARY

Mr. Ezeobi has been an enrolled member of the Fellowship since March 2021, first at Ashland Covenant Chapel in Lagos State and, since his transfer of membership, at this Assembly's affiliated mission congregation. He completed the Fellowship's Diploma in Covenant Cantorial Studies and was commissioned as a Covenant Cantor by the Fellowship's Council of Elders. He is qualified to perform every duty listed above, and the Assembly has been without a music and catechesis minister since September 2025.

I respectfully request that this petition be approved.

Respectfully,

/s/ Cordelia N. Ashgrove

Rev. Dr. Cordelia N. Ashgrove

Senior Pastor, Harrowgate Covenant Assembly, Inc.

Signed under penalty of perjury this 22nd day of January, 2026.